

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 13

IOWA
WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — a cross-location dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Iowa's family courts and child-welfare system.

111

IOWA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 203 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 21 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING TIME

DATA AS OF
NOVEMBER 7, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
41 OF 99

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · IOWA

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in Iowa. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

Cynthia Hucks CONTINUED 1 / 2

ATTORNEY · WAPELLO · **14 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Barely touched my case- did not prepare me at all for our temp custody hearing. I should have gotten primary custody and she had every thing in her back pocket to use. I ended up getting 50/50. Never responded to emails. Charged me for every single one I sent her though. I paid a $3,000 retainer and she is now trying to bill me another $900. When my soon to be ex husband was calling my work multiple times and I notified her she said "how does this affect you?" I fired her, and while switching attorneys my soon to be ex husband was filing a complaint with the state to get me fired."*

> *"There is a lot to list but the two major take aways. 1. I paid her to file and argue a contempt of court for non visitation. She filed however she never scheduled a court date. 2. I have paid her nearly 15k and I honestly believe I would be far better off if I represented myself."*

> *"Filed a petition for custody WITHOUT stating a TPO was in effect, then continued the TPO hearing - twice, against 1st judge's orders - to July 30th, then filed to take custody to TRIAL, now scheduled July 13th - as per Judge Joel Yates, of course"* JEFFERSON

> *"She lied to me in her office and said it would be a conflict of interest if she were my attorney but proceeded to be the opposing parties attorney. I can give more detail if needed just email me."*

> *"She helped me leave my abuser and fight for what was fair for my children. She is a busy attorney just like any good one, but her job is implacable!"*

> *"She failed to provide me with court dates and tell me that i needed character affidavits in my daughter's custody case in 2010"*

> *"She used manipulation tactics to get her way, lied to court, pressured me to resolve our case outside of court, and very rude!"*

> *"Amazing lawyer, did everything I asked. She has helped me and so many other families"*

> *"Produced illegal documents. Placed me in a room alone with her and my abuse."*

> *"They moved up my court date. They tried to make me quick claim my house"*

> *"Read above notes regarding this individual"*

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Cynthia Hucks CONTINUED 2 / 2

ATTORNEY · WAPELLO · **14 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Litigation harassment and abuse"*

> *"Incredible attorney!"*

> *"She's one sided"*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/ia-cynthia-hucks/complaint-packet
Family-reported pattern context only. Each person must file only their own truthful, first-hand complaint using their own facts, dates, evidence, orders, transcripts, and documents.

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Joel D. Yates

JUDGE · WAPELLO · **5 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"I was told to settle before a trial because this judge would not roll in my favor, no matter what because I wasn't man. The opposing party I had Cynthia Hucks and I was told she had him in her pocket. Was told he does not believe in 50-50 or joint. I was told by my last attorney to not go up against my ex with this judge because he does not rule in favor of father's and does not think 50-50 is ever in the best interest of the child always rules for mothers. I was told Cynthia has him in her pocket."*

> *"Ignored violations of TPO, extended TPO hearing without addressing violations or following previous judge's orders (Amber Thompson), told me to file an answer to the mediation petition filed against me (Cynthia D. Hucks) and postponed TPO hearing to July 30th. Now has signed a motion to go to TRIAL FOR CUSTODY on July 13th for a child PROTECTED FROM PETITIONER by the TPO which isn't to be heard (if not continued AGAIN) on July 30th..."* JEFFERSON

> *"DHS allowed the father do a bridge for child support even though the child stays with him two days a week. I requested to move the date to an-other date any other date but one it is set for due to my appeal hearing being on that date. He refused. It's clear they all work together when I can't get one court date moved. Extremely frustrating."* HENRY

> *"He denied me constitutional rights to direct the care and upbringing of my children. There was a hearing over the childrens cell phones I wanted access too. He ordered phones be turned over to CFR Magistrate Misty White and all evidence was deleted that I needed for evidence of opposing parties psychological abuse to my children"*

> *"Read above notes regarding this individual"*

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01 NAMED COURT ACTORS, CONTINUED

Reyna Wilkens

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · LOUISA · **5 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"Removed my kids from me without knowing the exact situation nor having met my kids and I at all—at that time. She is also completely against me getting my kids back when I have 14 NEGATIVE test results— one being a hair stat. Repeatedly asks the judge to put a pat ch on me when I am allergic to adhesive and have shown proof of my allergies and submitted them as evidence."* DES MOINES COUNTY

> *"Made life altering decisions for both MY DAUGHTERS initially with out ever actually talking to or meeting either one of them. She did finally have a phone conversation with them towards the very end of my termination case."*

> *"She was completely one sided and unprofessional in staff meetings as well as in court. Refused to admit there was no evidence and that the child was a habitual story teller which she also repeatedly admitted in court."* HENRY

> *"Gal had not even met with my 2 granddaughters until we brought it up in court. She would chohurse them on what to say! She told me, just let LHawk take them, who knows he may just hand them over in 3-4 years."*

> *"One phone call and hasn't spoke to me since."*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/ia-reyna-wilkens/complaint-packet
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Ryan Mitchell

GAL / CHILD REPRESENTATIVE · WAPELLO · **3 SUBMISSIONS**

> *"He was the initial attorney on my case and did not report to the judge the facts about my ex and the abuse towards my children and I and did not disclose to the judge the violation of my rights just because I went to the courthouse to get my child from my ex who had already won contempt from and my DHS case was closed none of this was brought up in court"*

> *"He couldn't show content on joint legal custody and got me child support for 4 kids and I only have 3. Didn't fight to remove the dual order and then withdrew after the money ran out. He cost me over $15,000 due to his incompetence and still going up monthly"*

> *"Not one time met or spoke to my children or I."*

Create Complaint Packet: https://my.standwithmeg.com/reports/actors/ia-ryan-mitchell/complaint-packet
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Public threshold rule: Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

IOWA AT A GLANCE.

Across 111 Iowa families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED
203
111 of 111 families reported child counts

MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN
$229,000
median across 25 families reporting 3+ categories

MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
21
of parenting time

WENT PRO SE
48.6%
54 of 111 who answered; 33 of 111 ran out of money

SUBMISSIONS
111

AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY
1.8

FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN
111 of 111

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
41

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Iowa families — and families across every represented location — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

03 THE COST OF IOWA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	62	$8,750	$46,109	$2,858,750
Lost Wages	46	$10,000	$192,433	$8,851,901
Other Court Fees	26	$45	$7,870	$204,614
Therapy / Evaluations	32	$850	$5,533	$177,070
Reunification Services	18	$0	$878	$15,800
GAL Fees	26	$500	$4,665	$121,300
Asset Loss [1]	38	$20,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (25 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	$229,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least $1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median ($20,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



04 WHO IS REPORTING · IOWA

Most families documenting in Iowa are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children. Percentages below use only families who answered that specific topic.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed	38	34%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago	24	22%
Case closed: within last 2 years	21	19%
Not provided	10	9%
Not in court but still affected	9	8%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS	53	48%
Family Court Only	34	31%
CPS Only	18	16%
Unknown	6	5%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years	41	37%
6 months – 1 year	27	24%
5 – 10 years	16	14%
Less than 6 months	9	8%
3 – 5 years	8	7%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access	33	30%
Full Custody	19	17%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)	16	14%
50/50 Joint	15	14%
Children in Foster Care	13	12%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Wapello	25	25%
Polk	9	9%
Benton	4	4%
Dallas	4	4%
Des Moines	3	3%
Scott	3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)	36	32%
Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)	22	20%
High Conflict Divorce	16	14%
Other	12	11%
Other: (Short answer)	7	6%

05 PARENT VOICES — IOWA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Iowa comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.

> *This nightmarish state intervention was instigated by a jealous ex (who quit his job at REM Iowa over a couple of the mentally impared patients apparent accusing him of *grape*), which DHS and Four Oaks corruptly weaponized through illegal gossip, forced drug allegations, and [...]*
>
> — RIANNE

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

The court system erased siblings from other children's life while letting the ex move in with his mom and legally kid nap the kids.while other siblings wonder what happened as no contact came even though it was allowed. No evidence heard just a pay off.

— IOWA PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM IOWA

Iowa DCF/CPS is totally corrupt & is has destroyed my daughter Katina's heart & life & mine.. just to get bonuses & paychecks!

— NANCY

They Stole our Lives for their financial Gain, destroyed out whole family major Trauma

— RENADA

Iowa CPS wrongfully founded me of child abuse despite a lack of credible evidence, failed to preserve or produce proof of my timely appeal submission, and has continued to uphold that finding through a procedurally flawed process. Their actions have directly contributed to [...]

— LINDSAY

It have brought up so much from my childhood from being in the system and the trauma my children are now going through.

— GENESIS

Left my family ripped apart, traumatized, and motherless.

— NICOLE

Lost my son to a corrupt DHS/CPS System

— KODY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *They have tore our family apart lied on us manipulated us ripped grandkids away from loving grandparents*
>
> — CASSIE

They are continuing to ensure that my children and I cannot have peace or space to heal, we are forced to deal with a landlord who has been seeking to evict us since "the breadwinner" left, we are displaced, and my constitutional rights are being blatantly, obviously and [...]

— ANDREA

They literally destroyed and tore apart my family piece by piece until I literally had NOTHING left!!!

— STEPHANIE

These people have created such havoc in our lives. Mychildren have been ripped away us for false drug test results that came from the lab that are inaccurate and have kept my children from us without increasing visitation because I won't do what they want me to do. I habe asked [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The courts were allowed to violate every constitutional protected right of parent and children. Record everything, video footage, audio, document.

— DEREK

Emotionally abused my children by distorting the facts of the case and withholding visitation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has ripped our family apart. We are grandparents raising three grandchildren, and they took the girls for alleged alleged sexual assault. there is not that much evidence and supposedly this happened years ago and I just want a girls to come home but they won't even [...]

— RENEE

Destroyed it. Destroyed our mental health, our stability, our trust in the system

— AMBER

The system has failed us and ripped us limb from limb

— JEANANE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Ruined my children's quality of life. We lost precious years and time we will never gain back!*
>
> — PATRICIA

The system stole my children and sold them for financial incentives from the federal government. Years of lost time gone forever no amount of money can pay for what they have stolen from us.

— ERICA

Alienated me from my kids for at least a decade.

— DAVID

It has taken the two things I love the most in this world away from me all while trying to take my freedom for no reason other than to back this case up. That all this conduct or misconduct rather protocol violations straight broken laws committed by deputies investigators [...]

— STEVEN

The system took my children based off false allegations and assumptions. The system affected my 21 year healthcare career in bed side nursing by placing me on a registry and blocking my ability to appeal. The system took everything from me, but they will never take my dignity. I [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

She helped my children and I even tho we had barely any money and I'm thankful with her for life!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has torn my life apart with no end in sight. Now they want to send my daughter to another state for treatment.

— LONI

What the attorney and mother has done to my son, by keeping his children from him and me the grandma is so uncalled for. He is such a good father to his children but the mom does not know how to co parent and follow custody orders.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They moved up my court date. They tried to make me quick claim my house

— COURTNEY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *They didn't just take my children—they fractured our sense of safety, turned our home into a case file, and left a family grieving each other while still alive.*
>
> — DESTINY

It was hell that still has never end. Not amount of time can be given back and it has traumatized me and my children and had an effect on my youngest childs custody. Not being allowed to see my youngest child. And not being allowed to seek safety from my ex to give guardian ship [...]

— LOIS

It has emotionally drained our family and our daughter who begs to come home every visit we get with her..

— EMILY AND IAN

Family fraud court has annihilated my family, my financial security, my physical, mental and even my dental health. Family court has triggered my C-PTSD so badly that I am unable to work, unable to trust others, unable to be happy, unable to relate to anyone that is not mourning [...]

— JODI

Our family has been destroyed by DHS, Foster Care, Judicial system, Familes First, 4 Oaks, it has caused so much pain & heartache. Now I have custody of my oldest granddaughter, but the youngest is still with the Bio father of my oldest granddaughter.

— MELISSA

They tortured me, put a complete halt on every bit of progress I made, and put my son in absolute very serious danger.

— BRANDY

Iowa systems are not in place to help kids and families but are to keep other systems operational by money and trafficking families through the systems Pay for play. Most know eachother and are an army of 1.

— TINA

Caused me more ptsd then I needed, the physical sickness i have been under cause its draining me mentally, harder to get believed

— JESSICA

Family court is not about justice. It's about how much justice you can afford.

— DION

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Tore my family apart, hard to get a job,*
>
> — RONDA

The courts today care more about protecting workers right, than that of parents. Children are not just a bonus check there our future, why would we want to ruin there childhood with lies and coaching.

— PAULA

Irreparable harm and damage done to my children and I. No monetary damages will ever fixed the damage this court has done to my family. Our lives will never be the same again. #ParentsUngrounded

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The DHS system tore my child away from to their father- the one who falsely reported me a total of nine times to get out of paying child support and alimony. DHS believed every word that man said and couldn't see the blatant misuse of the system.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We ended up moving to prevent further interaction with. Alexandra Murphy as she has now charged me with child abuse 3 times in 4 years when there was non.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Removed my kids and sepr Erased them let a sexual predator walk free without filing charges against him and caused me to lose my home as well as giving out my case I formation to those whom shouldn't have it

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This site is Bullshit!

— FRED

Money hungry. Doesn’t do what is in the best interests of her clients. 0/10 recommend. Put your money elsewhere.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ptsd for me, emotional damage for my mom, siblings and grandmother

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

64 Iowa parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 44 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — IOWA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Iowa families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

> This nightmarish state intervention was instigated by a jealous ex (who quit his job at REM Iowa over a couple of the mentally impared patients apparent accusing him of *grape*), which DHS and Four Oaks corruptly weaponized through illegal gossip, forced drug allegations, and malicious sabotage. The intimidation escalated to the point where they even sent my sister's DHS worker Ashley HabHab to show up at my door to deliver the initial report on the exact day she had her final visit with her children. Enabled by my own attorney's sickening malpractice and fake sympathy, this systemic corruption stole our child, fractured our relationship, and left my grandmother profoundly depressed and permanently robbed of the grandbabies who were are her entire world-almost as much as they are mine.. those two girls were my best friends my everything thats just what i was meant do was be their mommy, even one of the four oaks workers told me theyd never seen a parent and their children have the kind of bond that i had with my baby girls.... and they just stripped me of my most valued and most important title the one that made me whole; "Mommy". Our whole family has just slowly fell apart since all of this. My grandma barely smiles anymore. Im scared theyre gonna forget us, or hate me when they get older. Im defeated.
>
> — RIANNE

> Iowa DCF/CPS is totally corrupt & is has destroyed my daughter Katina's heart & life & mine.. just to get bonuses & paychecks!
>
> — NANCY

> The court system erased siblings from other children's life while letting the ex move in with his mom and legally kid nap the kids.while other siblings wonder what happened as no contact came even though it was allowed. No evidence heard just a pay off.
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> Iowa CPS wrongfully founded me of child abuse despite a lack of credible evidence, failed to preserve or produce proof of my timely appeal submission, and has continued to uphold that finding through a procedurally flawed process. Their actions have directly contributed to prolonged separation from my children and ongoing harm to my parental rights.
>
> — LINDSAY

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

It have brought up so much from my childhood from being in the system and the trauma my children are now going through.

— GENESIS

Left my family ripped apart, traumatized, and motherless.

— NICOLE

Lost my son to a corrupt DHS/CPS System

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They have tore our family apart lied on us manipulated us ripped grandkids away from loving grandparents

— CASSIE

They are continuing to ensure that my children and I cannot have peace or space to heal, we are forced to deal with a landlord who has been seeking to evict us since "the breadwinner" left, we are displaced, and my constitutional rights are being blatantly, obviously and outright violated - continually - as they aren't even sticking to the orders being filed. They won't even let me file electronically, but my abuser was given an exemption from e-filing previously! I have a special needs child from a previous relationship, a son who is NOT biologically of the abuser, either - this is outright warfare against the innocent. I ended a 7 year abusive relationship last September and they STILL will NOT stop coming at us! I am forced to continue to do everything myself as well as I can and they just keep coming. I could represent myself, if not for the blatant allowance of contempt and conflicting court orders and JOEL YATES!

— ANDREA

They literally destroyed and tore apart my family piece by piece until I literally had NOTHING left!!!

— STEPHANIE

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

These people have created such havoc in our lives. Mychildren have been ripped away us for false drug test results that came from the lab that are inaccurate and have kept my children from us without increasing visitation because I won't do what they want me to do. I habe asked for almost a year to get the results from the lab that does the testing and nobody would help me. I finally received the lab date package and mow have proof that their tests are faulty and not accurate ... my first attorney flat out said my office will mot be fighting these results and we will not be requesting anything from the lab. If he would have done what I requested a year ago they would have had nothing to use to take my children.

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— RENEE

Destroyed it. Destroyed our mental health, our stability, our trust in the system

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It has emotionally drained our family and our daughter who begs to come home every visit we get with her..

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— JODI

Our family has been destroyed by DHS, Foster Care, Judicial system, Familes First, 4 Oaks, it has caused so much pain & heartache. Now I have custody of my oldest granddaughter, but the youngest is still with the Bio father of my oldest granddaughter.

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Ptsd for me, emotional damage for my mom, siblings and grandmother

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Did everything I asked and even more, an amazing lawyer

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Judge Milani's risked my 1 year old's safety by giving a sex offender unsupervised access to her. 1 year old, with no way to protect herself. Is that what's in the best interest of the child?

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Cynthia Hucks ruined my life. The only thing I got to keep in my divorce was my kids. But there were stipulations with that also. The ex could take the kids if he felt he needed to. She is a vile person and only thinks of what she can gain.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They took a family who loved each other and tore them apart.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court’s six-year custody battle has ignored evidence, alienated your son, and cost your family milestones

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

HHS removed my son without a hearing based on his grandmother's lies on an affidavit without even speaking to me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Cynthia completely destroyed my son's up bringing along with both of our mental health and he will carry that for the rest of his life. My son and I both have PTSD stemming from this, it is all documented.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My oldest daughter has now been hospitalized in a pysch ward due to her step mom as of january this year I had hearing in feb and proved abuse in the home but the courts said they did no wrong my youngest child stated this last week she wanted to kill herself at her dad's cause she isn't loved....im tryung to contact a lawyer and get things changed but will see

— AMBER

It has ruined my life

— HEATHER

DHS refused to encourage reunification. Put my daughter in teachers home instead of family. My daughter has been manipulated against me. I can’t concentrate at work, depression, PTSD, anxiety. This has destroyed our family!!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Judge Joel Yates and the Wapello county court and family system have zero interest in learning about parental alienation. They are not therapists and do not take actual therapists recommendations into account. Joel Yates is incompetent in family court matters as he does not keep up with research, therapy recommendations, nor does he see any issues in separating siblings and families due to parental alienation.

— KYLIE

Caused severe P.T.S.D. as well as put a major damper on my personal relationship with my daughters as well as my current relationship & my social life due to D.H.H.S. coming to my home weekly.

— BRIAN

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Left out an older child by friends of the court and let exes mom get guardianship where ex lived... because money matters more than saftey when everyone in the circle knows eachothers secrets"

— AMBER

I've missed time with my daughter. Holidays and what not. She's been severely struggling without her mom present. No concern from the courts and no interest in reunification.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn apart my entire family

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They took a civil divorce and caused it to not be civil and then dismissed herself from the case and leaving us in financial ruin and not divorce and no agreement in place for our son.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Riped a daughter away from her mother to place her with someone who is going to hurt her again. He is now on the run, still in active addiction, but he was the In better interest for our daughter?

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn out whole family apart

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This process has been deeply taxing on both me and my family, as I continue to advocate for my child's need for stability and security. Too often, the system appears focused on achieving equality on paper, influenced by underlying biases, rather than prioritizing what is truly in the child's best interest.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

> I had 2 cases. The one I'm reporting on is my second case. I take full accountability that in my first I did not take necessary action. However, despite me absolutely taking all action requested AND THEN SOME in my second case I was viewed the same as I had literally all the same exact people involved as my first case. They were literally the personification of the ideology "once an addict always an addict" despite me paying out of pocket for drug tests that proved otherwise
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

64 full approved Iowa comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a public, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Iowa report comes from Iowa respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Iowa — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 111 Iowa families reporting here are not the universe of Iowa families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. Response counts and percentages use the number of families who answered that specific topic or financial field. The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – November 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

Dollar fields exclude blank, negative, and obvious data-entry artifact values above the report's field caps. When asset-loss values contain a strong statistical outlier, the asset-loss mean and total are suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county or regional field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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